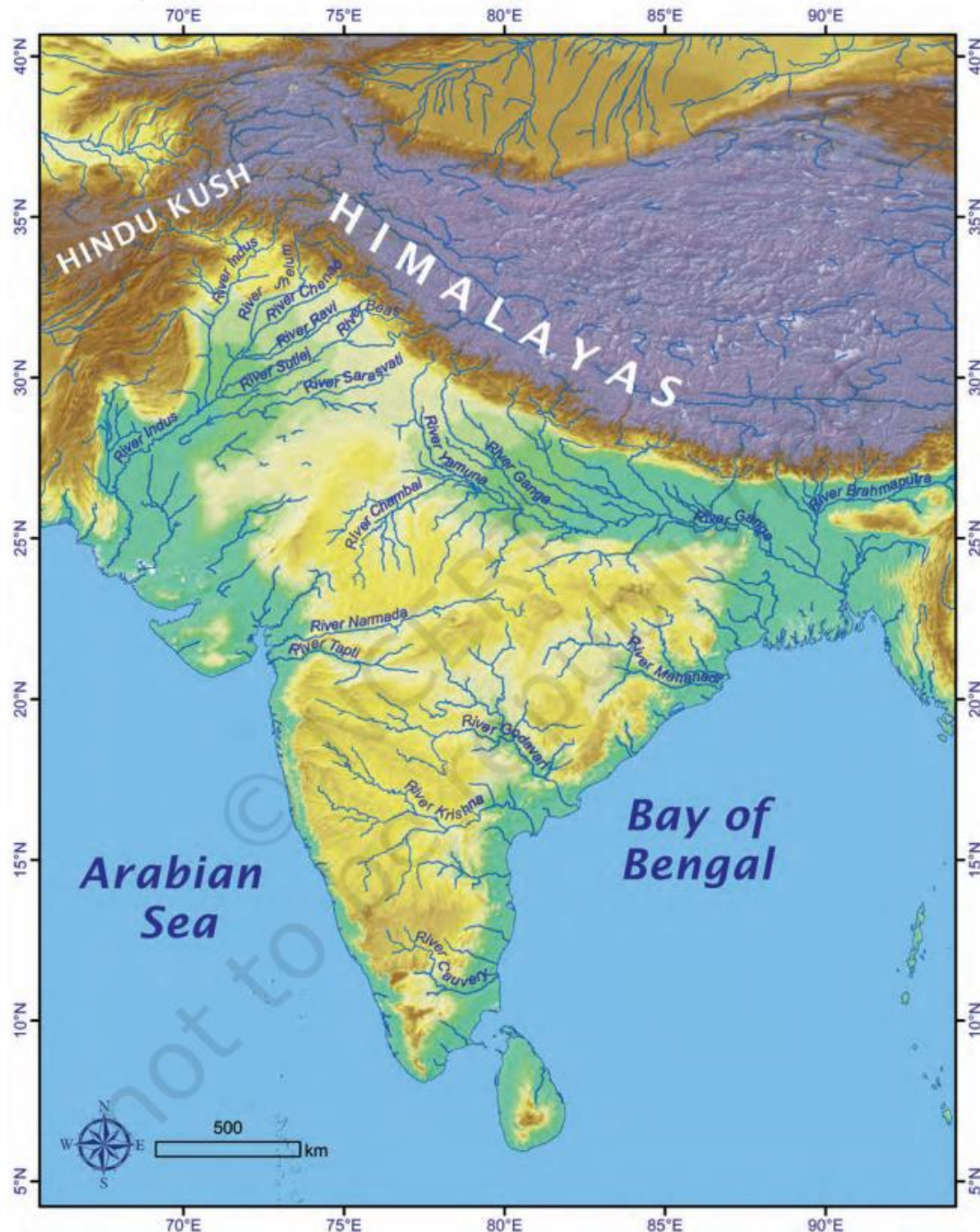


Chapter – 5: India, that is Bharat

In India at a very early time the spiritual and cultural unity was made complete and became the very stuff of the life of all this great surge of humanity between the Himalayas and the two seas. — Sri Aurobindo

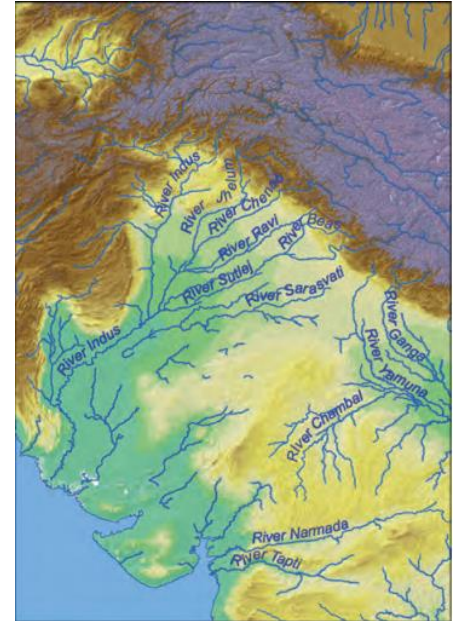


- India – we know today – modern nation – defined borders, defined states, known population
- Very diff. – 500 yrs. ago – 2000 yrs. ago – even 5000 yrs. ago
- This region – Indian subcontinent – diff. names – shifting boundaries
- India's past, evolution – many diff. src. to learn
- History – India – many names – both by – **inhabitants** and visitors from outside
- These names – come to us – ancient texts, accounts – travelers, pilgrims – inscriptions

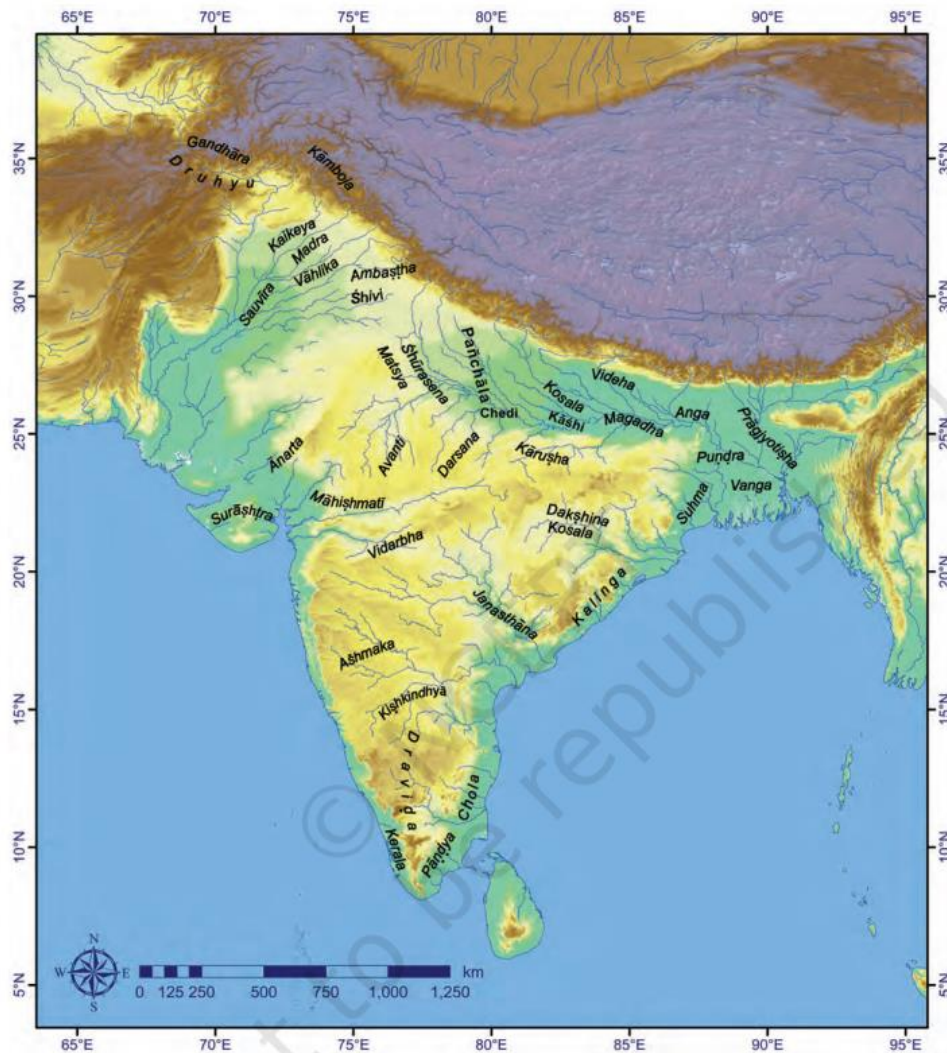
How Indians named India?

- Rig Veda – India's most ancient text – several 1000 yrs. old

- Northwest region – subcontinent – ‘Sapta Sindhava’ – land of seven rivers – stated in Rig Veda
- Sindhava – comes from ‘Sindhu’ – refers to – Indus River – OR – river in general
- Moving on – names – other parts of India – appear in literature
- Mahabharata – India’s most famous text – lists many regions –
 - Kashmir – more or less today’s Kashmir
 - Kurukshetra – parts of Haryana today
 - Vanga – parts of Bengal
 - Pragjyotisha – roughly today’s Assam
 - Kaccha – today’s Kutch
 - Kerala – more or less today’s Kerala



- When – name – entire subcontinent?
- Ancient Indian text – difficult to date – not easy to answer
- Mahabharata – mention – ‘Bharat Varsha’ and ‘Jambudvipa’ – scholars agree – composed – few centuries BCE onwards



- Bharat Varsha –
 - Entire subcontinent – text includes – various rivers and people
 - Meaning – country of Bharatas – name – 1st in Rig Veda – refers to main Vedic grp. of people
 - Later literature – several kings – Bharata
- Jambudvipa –
 - Meaning – island of the fruit of jamun tree

- This tree – common – native to India – called – ‘jambul tree’, ‘Malabar plum tree’, etc.
- Good clue – Indian Emperor – Ashoka – about – 250 BCE
- He left – many inscriptions – one of them – used ‘Jambudvipa’ – describe whole of India – at that time – included – today’s Bangladesh, Pakistan and some parts of Afghanistan
- Few centuries later – ‘Bharata’ name – more popular – used generally for Indian subcontinent
- Ancient text – *Vishnu Purana* –
 - uttaram yat samudrasya himādreścaiva dakṣiṇam varṣam tad bhāratam nāma ...
 - “The country that lies north of the ocean and south of the snowy mountains is called Bhārata.”
- Bharata name – used even today –
 - North India – generally written – Bharat
 - South India – generally written – Bharatam
- Interesting – diff. parts – adopted similar definition – India
- Poem – Tamil literature – 2000 yrs. ago – praises a king – known as –
 - From Kumari in the south
 - From great mountain in north
 - From oceans on the east and on the west
- Ancient Indians – knew geography – well

How Foreigners Named India

- 1st foreigners – mention India – Persians – ancient inhabitants of Iran
- 6th century BCE – Persian Emperor – military campaign – gained control – region – Indus River – earlier – Sindhu
- Earlier records – Persians – referred to India – Hind, Hidu, Hindu – adaptations of Sindhu – their language
- Ancient Persian – Hindu – purely geographical term
- Based on Persian src. – ancient Greeks – named the region – Indoi OR Indike – dropped H of Hindu – this letter – did not exist in Greek language
 - Sindhu → Hindhu → Indoi / Indike
- Ancient Chinese – interacted with India – several text – refer to India – Yintu OR Yindu – originates from Sindhu
 - Sindhu → Hindhu → Indu → Yindu
- Xuanzang –
 - Formerly – Hiuen Tsang – visited India from China – 7th century CE
 - Visited many parts – met scholars – collected Buddhists text – returned after 17 yrs.
 - Translated manuscripts – Sanskrit to Chinese
 - Several other Chinese scholars – visited India
- Another Chinese word – derived from Sindhu – Tianzhu – also means – heavenly master – reflects the respect – Chinese had for India – land of the Buddha
- More familiar – Hindustan – 1st used – Persian inscription – 1800 yrs. ago
- Later – this term – used by most invaders – describe Indian subcontinent